

*Introduction* it is given a brief note at the end of the chapter on Ezra and Nehemiah. By commentators the two "books," Ezra and First Esdras, are usually kept entirely separate. If the commentaries on Chronicles and on Ezra-Nehemiah mention First Esdras at all, it is only as a *curiosum*. Bertholet, in his commentary on Ezra and Nehemiah (in Marti's *Kurzer Hand-Commentar*), does, indeed, devote a section to the Greek Ezra in his introduction, pp. xvi, xvii, but his statements regarding it are notably confused and ill-digested, while in the commentary itself he makes no serious attempt to use it. In general, his attitude toward the apocryphon is characteristic of a certain irresponsible method of dealing with sources which is far too prevalent in modern Old Testament criticism: any comparison of the Greek Esdras text, in occasional difficult passages, is a work of supererogation, of which the commentator may boast; the idea that he is in duty bound to consult it *all the time*, and to make a really critical study of it does not suggest itself.

The commentaries on First Esdras, again, have not brought us far toward an understanding of its origin and true character; as might be expected from the fact that all the commentators have believed the book to be simply a late and "historically worthless" compilation. The parallel portions of the canonical books are only occasionally consulted, and then in the most perfunctory way. In the *Kurzgefasstes exegetisches Handbuch zu den Apokryphen des A. T.*, by Fritzsche-Grimm—the one thoroughgoing and scholarly commentary on the Old Testament Apocrypha, but now long outgrown—the treatment of First Esdras (by Fritzsche) is below the level of the rest; chiefly, no doubt, for the reason already given. No commentary on the book that has appeared since that date (1851) is worthy of serious attention. Lupton, in Wace's *Speaker's Commentary* (1888), is very superficial; and both he and Zöckler (1891) are equal to the feat of subjecting the book to a fresh study without even finding out that it offers us a separate, extra-canonical translation from the Semitic! In the critical examination of text and versions next to nothing has been done, though this is a most promising field for investigation. The statements as to these things which now and then appear are for the most part either false or inaccurate. Fritzsche (*Comm.*, p. 9) asserted that the best text of First Esdras is to be found in the uncial B and the cursives 52 and 55, and this most misleading